



▲ CAPT VIRIATO FERNANDES, *55*

| CONGRESS |
South Goa

Having gone through a series of near-amoebic splits as veterans like former CM Digambar Kamat and Michael Lobo left to join the BJP, retaining the South Goa seat became crucial for the state Congress unit. Enter Indian Navy officer-turned-activist Capt. Viriato Fernandes, who replaced the incumbent Congress MP, the 78-year-old Francisco Sardinha. As a navy engineer, Fernandes was part of the military mobilisation during the 1999 Kargil war and took part in Operation Talwar, which sought to choke Pakistan's trade channels. After an early retirement, he was associated with the NGO Goencho Avaaz, and later joined the Congress. An electoral foray in 2022, from the Dabolim assembly constituency, ended in failure. Now comes parliamentary success, on the back of support from the Roman Catholics, who form about 36 per cent of the population in Salcette, the region around Margao, helping him defeat the BJP's Pallavi Dempo.



▲ MANJU SHARMA, *64*

| BJP | ***Jaipur***

Manju Sharma's father Bhanwar Lal Sharma was the Hawa Mahal MLA six times in a row from 1977 to 1998; she lost it by 580 votes in 2008. Ever since, this postgraduate from Kanodiya College stuck to running her jewellery business and a few party posts. This year, she was chosen over sitting MP Ramcharan Bohra to contest from Jaipur, a parliamentary seat that comprises the assembly segments of Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma and deputy CMs Diya Kumari and Prem Chand Bairwa. The BJP considers Jaipur a safe seat, and it was no surprise that Manju defeated former state transport minister Pratap Singh Khachariyawas of the Congress by more than 300,000 votes.

▶ CAPT. BRIJESH CHOWTA, *42*

| BJP | ***Dakshina Kannada, Karnataka***



Chowta entered politics after an eight-year stint in the army, where he served in 8 Gorkha Rifles. After retiring early, his aim was to get into policymaking and administration. Hailing from a family with strong RSS ties, he joined the BJP's youth wing, the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha, in 2013, and became the state secretary of its Karnataka unit in 2023. A year later, he was handed the ticket to Dakshina Kannada in place of sitting MP Nalin Kumar Kateel. Having won, after besting Congress's Padmaraj Poojary, he plans to develop the Dakshina Kannada coastline by improving road and rail infrastructure connecting to the Mangaluru port.



▲ KULDEEP INDORA, *54*

| CONGRESS |
Ganganagar (SC), Rajasthan

Son of former Rajasthan minister Heera Lal Indora, Kuldeep had two unsuccessful assembly poll outings. Still, the Congress gave him a ticket, as he worked hard to get Anoopgarh, in Ganganagar, district status, and wife Seema is ex-chairperson of Anoopgarh municipality. Kuldeep himself has been a party national secretary in charge of a few states. An 88,000-vote win over the BJP's Priyanka Balan Meghwal will now see him in the Lok Sabha, where the newly-minted MP hopes to raise issues of Dalits and agriculture, as his constituency is part of the Indira Gandhi Canal-irrigated belt.